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George Shearing

Pianist George Shearing was born in England on August 13, 1919. He received his first musical training at the Linden Lodge School for the Blind and his lack of sight proved no hindrance to an eventual career as a jazz pianist. He was recording by 1936 and quickly became a household name in England, being voted the top British pianist by Melody Maker *from 1939-1946. His desire for a larger audience brought him to the U.S. in 1946 and his career has blossomed since then. George has performed and recorded solo, as an accompanist to jazz vocalists, with symphony orchestras, and as a leader of big bands. During the 50s, his combination of vibes, guitar and piano made his quintet the top jazz ensemble in the country. He has composed a number of jazz classics, including "Lullaby of Birdland." He continues to tour and record, and has received an Honorary Doctorate from Hamilton College.*

George was interviewed by his good friend and frequent musical companion Joe Williams in New York City on March 8, 1996. Monk Rowe and Leslie Gourse participated briefly in the interview.

JW: This is for the archives at Hamilton College. George, I've often wondered how an Englishman like you comes to the point you are with the music, and the legacy and the history of the music, and to understand it so well, and to go to innovations of your own from where you came from, relating to this music. How did you get to this music I want to know? The jazz, that good sound that you give us all over.

GS: I was brought up on Jimmy Lunceford.

JW: Ohhhhh.

GS: There was an all blind band in 1937. Fifteen musicians. Fifteen blind guys, taught to be musicians, from being chair caners, basket makers—

JW: What?

GS: They caned chairs. They made baskets, and they were taught to play instruments and be musicians. And the scores were done in Braille. We had Lunceford's "Stratosphere," Benny Carter's "Night Fall."

JW: Did you have his suite too?

GS: Yeah, we had all the Braille charts. And I'm the only one that didn't need it, and I'd pick it up by ear right away. The theme song for the band by the way was "I'll See You In My Dreams." And the only fully sighted man was a man named Claude Bampton, who was a kind of semi-professional band leader in England. He had this huge baton, you know whit, whit, whit, [sings] "I'll See You In My Dreams." One night, you know blind people always have to set up in a theater a little bit earlier than the sighted. It takes us a bit longer. And Claude said, "Okay fellas, you ready?" One guy said, "No, just a minute, I

lost my eye." His glass eye had fallen out, rolled across the stage, and there was 15 blind guys down on the floor—

JW: Oh, wait a minute, George—

GS: I kid you not, this is the God's honest truth. Fifteen blind guys down on the floor looking for this eye.

JW: And you found it?

GS: They found it. And they didn't massacre it at all, they found it. He put it in. Whit, whit, whit — "I'll See You In —" One night as a matter of fact, we were at Benny Carter's house for dinner. And I had a tape recorder with me. And I had a recording of the band, the all-blind band playing "Night Fall." And he says, "Who is that?" I said, "Well you know the tune, don't you?" "Yeah." So I explained to him about the all-blind band. So I guess you know there was, jazz came into England and we copy.

JW: Yes.

GS: I mean, we copy.

JW: But you went on to innovation though you know. You went from assimilation to innovation.

GS: I've always wanted to come here since I was about 16. And the war of course was going on. I was born in '19, a year later than you, Joe.

JW: Yes. We are young people. We are 70 years young.

GS: Yes. What did Eubie Blake say? He says, "If I'd have known I was going to live this long I'd have taken better care of myself." But anyway, I always wanted to come to the States. And you know how it is, you know, when you hear Torme's "California Suite," you say oh, boy, California, you know. Walk along Hollywood Boulevard, and huh, so this is Hollywood Boulevard. But the way it's built up you know. I came over first on the boat on The America. And I literally landed in New York, put my foot on the ground and I said this is where it all started.

JW: Yes.

GS: This was 1946. I was born in '19 so what was I, 27?

JW: Then you met John Levy and the group, here.

GS: John Levy, I met John Levy and the group, and John Levy did recording with me before, oh, well about the same time the quintet started. 1949.

JW: Do you get a chance to meet and listen to Louis Armstrong in person?

GS: Yeah. Oh, yeah.

JW: You did?

GS: Yeah.

JW: Because he was part of our beginnings, too.

GS: Oh, gosh.

JW: So simple.

GS: I'll never forget one wonderful thing with Louis Armstrong. I had the quintet in the — I want to say Casino Theater in Toronto. And around the corner from there was a restaurant and I took the guys to dinner. And everything had sauce upon sauce upon sauce. So I ate the banana fritters, which was the only plain thing I could find. And in comes Louis you know. "Oh," he said, "dig old Shearing getting in on the freebies there." He said, "That cat's eating so fast he looks like he's smiling."

JW: Oh, Louis was a great tease.

GS: Unfortunately I never got over here in time to hear the Lunceford band.

JW: Oh, man, well I can tell you anybody who did can tell you what an experience that was. They would swing you into bad health.

GS: Great show band too, weren't they?

JW: Yes they was.

GS: When they'd play those shout things they'd all the front line stand up and — a great show band.

JW: Oh, man, they would play the music for people like the Miller Brothers and Lois, and what is that, the tap dancing teams, and for ballroom danc--. They played everything absolutely elegant. What was that thing they played [scats].

GS: Yes. "Prelude Number 7."

JW: "Prelude Number 7."

GS: And old Willie Smith.

JW: Willie was a beautiful —

GS: [scats].

JW: Willie Smith and that whole bunch. But they could swing you into — I mean dance you to death. When they would start playing "River St. Marie" and they'd change keys, they'd say [scats]. Oh man.

GS: Ellie and I talk all the time about the time that we went to Rockefeller Center for New Year's and danced to Sy Oliver. And I said, "Can you give me a Lunceford?" First of all he played several Lunceford charts. I said, "Ellie, this is as close as you're going to get." But oh, that band.

JW: They would dance us to death when they'd come to Chicago, you know? Every number. And the ballads were just as pretty.

GS: Well you and I have experienced some things with the Basie tour, night after night after night with them.

JW: Yes. Listening to Sarah Vaughan and Jimmie Jones and Richard Davis and Roy Haynes with the Basie band playing those wonderful charts. Some by Al Cohn, some by Ernie Wilkins.

GS: And Quincy.

JW: And Quincy too, yeah, he had charts by Quincy at that time. And we'd get in the audience and you'd be wet as I remember. You had your towel on, to listen to her in that group make music. Well there was a lot of things happening musically. You became very innovative though, with the Latin rhythms. You went through your Latin period there that was very exciting I thought.

GS: That's because before the quintet even, Buddy DeFranco, John Levy on bass, Denzil Best on drums and me, before the quintet, in the Clique Club in New York, opposite the Machito band, and when I start thinking about that, I could hear rhythmic complexity in that thing that was even ahead of some more simplified forms of jazz. Because in true African style, they would blend three or four rhythms together. A conga drum four and [scats]. And then the cowbell [scats].

JW: And the bass going [scats].

GS: Yeah, yeah.

JW: You'd hear the bass, I mean they'd put so much.

GS: Every one of those rhythms would just blend together.

JW: Yes. I was listening to something, Machito, on the air just yesterday when I was flying in, one of those things. And they were just so beautiful. You couldn't help but be moved. On the plane you find yourself beating and adding things and anticipating. And that heartbeat thing that they could lay in there, like [scats].

GS: Yeah right.

JW: And the drum was in tune, you know.

GS: That's right. But nobody played the same thing. Nobody.

JW: No, they'd get [scats].

GS: That's right. There's this wonderful story about an Indian who came over here and played jazz over here and he went back home you know. And they said, "You know you've been in America too long. Why don't you make it simple? You know put the sock cymbal on two, seven, eleven and thirteen."

JW: I love it. Two, eleven — Oh my God. That's beautiful. It did get a little out there. Dizzy Gillespie and the fellas kind of upset up.

GS: Oh he was very authentic. Dizzy. Well Chano Pozo, you know, and that's where McKibbon learned all that stuff, from Chano Pozo. And then of course McKibbon came with me, and Tjader, Cal Tjader. And then Armando.

JW: Armando Peraza.

GS: Oh, boy. And I remember one day Max said to me, "I want to play something, you tell me where one is." [scats]. I said, "How's that again?" [scats]. He says, "One" [scats] — "one" [scats].

JW: One was out there. One was in front of the bar. “One” [scats].

GS: That was before Charlie had it.

JW: Oh my gosh. But it still works out, the simple things I think are really more moving and they do it better than anything. There’s a guy that says, “Keep it simple, stupid.” There’s nobody needs to know how clever, you don’t have to show anybody how clever you are. I mean when you’re playing two people I think if you keep it simple, you’re going to be a big, big success. That’s the way I look at that. Now your wife is over there buttering something— oh my God. Well I think we’d better cut right here for a moment, and let her butter him up so to speak.

[pause]

JW: George, I want to ask you something. I’m not so familiar with the computer age and what is happening with computers. And I’d like to ask you, what do you think, how is it going to help the music and bring our audiences to the live performance where it’s what it’s really about, because they can’t do anything on the electronics that would compare with a live, breathing performer. But do you think it’s going to help maybe enlarge our audience?

GS: I don’t think so.

JW: You don’t think so?

GS: I don’t think so. Because it’s through the advancement of technology that we have tapes and CDs and everything in our homes. And you take a day like this day that we’re doing this tape, and you have a choice of going home and listening to a definitive performance, or going out and hearing a live definitive performance. And while nothing will take care —

JW: Take the place of it.

GS: —take the place of live performance, certainly home performances can be pretty good and you can go make yourself a cup of tea in the middle of it. I don’t know, I wish I had a better outlook on it, but I really don’t.

JW: Well I—

GS: Do you agree with that by the way?

JW: I guess that we were lucky in a way that when I started, and you too, we played for dancing, and sang for dancing, and dancing brought people together. Girls and boys got together and danced and fraternized and what have you. And it’s something, it’s people just being made aware of the music and listening to the music at home, with all of its enhancements would say well like, “Gee I think I’d like to be there,” I think it would be nice. If we could only, some way, we could get the kids dancing again, the way they used to, I think it would be marvelous.

GS: A lot of that is visual I guess.

JW: Yes. Well feeling too. The feeling of holding someone in your arms and touching. And not only that, switching partners. I mean friends, they'd dance with each other you know. Boys and boys sometimes. Girls and girls. And now there's nothing wrong with it. It used to be they'd say — oops. But now there's nothing wrong with it you know. If they feel like it I guess it's okay.

GS: How many big bands are there today to go and hear in person?

JW: I don't know.

GS: Not a great many.

JW: No. I don't know.

GS: Remember the time I mean you'd go to the hotels in the City of New York, you'd get Ray McKinley in one place and you'd get Ellington in one place, and you'd get, you know.

JW: Yes. That's the way it was.

GS: Not anymore. In fact, even when I came over in 1946 and 47, you'd think I'll go here because Kenton is here. But you know he'd play "Artistry and Rhythm" and then maybe one more song, then he's accompanying a show. And that's fine but you don't hear very much of the band. But then there are all the clubs like Club DeLisa and you'd go down there and hear Red Saunders cut that show.

JW: And then play for dancing. Yeah. That was a wonderful time. I used to listen to the broadcasts coming from the different hotels too.

GS: Yes.

JW: You'd hear Benny Goodman and Woody Herman, Gus Arnheim, Coon Saunders, Lunceford of course, and Basie and Andy Kirk and Ellington. I remember a great band that I heard, beside Chick Webb, Benny Carter had a band broadcasting from ballrooms here in New York City and had Eddie, what's his name, "Canadian Sunset" had him on piano in fact.

GS: Who was that?

JW: Eddie, what was the guy that played "Canadian Sunset," had such a big hit out of "Canadian Sunset?"

MR: Eddie Wood?

LG: Heywood.

JW: Heywood. Yeah, Eddie Heywood, Yes. Leslie Gourse over there. Tell her — thank you, Leslie. Yeah, Eddie Heywood on piano [scats]. And Eddie was flying, oh, man. I heard that broadcast. I was in Chicago and I heard that. And we had a man named Bob Hawk in Chicago, broadcast a thing called "Red Hot and Low Down." And his theme was "East St. Louis Toodle-oo," Duke's original theme.

GS: Can you separate Duke and Strayhorn? Who wrote what? And can you tell by listening?

JW: Sometimes. But I have to sit and listen. I have to really listen.

GS: They truly are an extension of each other, aren't they? Ellington and Strayhorn?

JW: That's such a happy, happy, happy union.

GS: Yeah.

JW: I think he wanted to be like that, you know, with Tom Whaley, who also was a wonderful musician. You'd hear Duke tell him what he was going to do, and that was an experience, to hear him tell Tom Whaley, "well here, do our thing here and you know, B natural thing here, and you know, run this thing down, you know what we do, do our thing here." And he'd say, "Oh I know what you mean." Anybody else — Jimmie Jones is there, and Strayhorn was there, and said what the heck are they talking about?

GS: You know, a philosophy that Duke had, I always found very interesting. You'd get a new man in the band and he would very rarely ask that man to play like so-and-so and so-and-so. He says "I don't want that. I want that man to contribute what he has to contribute."

JW: There you go. That was Ellington, that was Basie. Basie had more people come through there, and it was whatever you had to contribute. That was what I was telling Leslie a while ago. I said Basie chose "Alright, O.K., You Win." Everything else in that repertoire I chose to do. I'd have to fight him to be able to do it somewhat, because he'd say "oh you don't need that, just do what you're doing."

GS: Will the Basie band return more, the Basie band, now that Frank is —

JW: They have.

GS: Yeah?

JW: Yeah. Grover has brought them right back to basic and Basie. Really. And it is a gorgeous thing to hear, it's really something to hear.

GS: Oh yeah. Well that's great. I can't blame Frank, I mean you know, he wants to put his own thing together and his own music and —

JW: He was an extension of Basie, as was Thad you know. Thad got his thing out there, and Frank should be able to get his own thing out there as well.

GS: But it's gone right back to Basie now, huh?

JW: Now it is, yes, it's back to—

GS: Do you applaud that?

JW: Oh yes. Young men in there like Bob Ojeda and people like that, Bob O. said, Man that was the reason I came over here in the first place, I wanted to play this music that we're playing now." He said, "I love Frank." He said, "I love Frank and I love Thad. But I came over here because I wanted to play this Basie music." It's back where he wanted it.

GS: Oh, thank goodness.

JW: And that's no bad place to be I want you to know. I want to thank you, George, for the archives, from our Hamilton College, yours and mine.

GS: It has been my pleasure, Joe. We have known, for as long as we've known each other, and that's 1948, that we could be dead dog tired and sit there and talk and enjoy every word that we say to each other. And it will be that way from here on, as it has been in the past.

JW: Thank you, George. Through snow and sludge and mud, here we are.

GS: Especially the mud.

JW: Good food, good drink, I love it. And we'll see you, Hamilton, yes we will.